



VoiceXML

What, now, is VoiceXML?

VoiceXML is a standard XML format used when building applications that feature voice interaction between humans and machines—as in you talking to the computer, and it talking to you.

Whose idea was it?

The World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) released the VoiceXML specification to standardise the way voice-enabled applications will work.

How does it work?

Just like HTML is a standard way to format a Web page so it can be understood by a browser, VoiceXML is a standard that works with a *voice browser*—something like a Web browser with a voice interface. It's transmitted using HTTP, and text is converted to speech at either end of the line.

Why did we need this?

As with all things, standardising a protocol for voice-enabled applications lets developers focus on important things like functionality. Moreover, by separating the application and the XML, users don't need to be tied to just one application—they can use different voice browsers if they so choose.

When did this begin?

The first VoiceXML specification was published by the W3C in May 2000; the latest 2.0 specification exists today only as a set of recommendations, and the future will see version 3.0 with a host of additional features and capabilities.

Where can I see it in action?

Thousands of applications now use VoiceXML, including the Opera Web browser. VoiceXML has found tremendous use in over-the-phone applications, like the one your cellular provider might offer—call a number, say a word, and get results.

Interview

Autodesk announced the shipping of Maya 8—the ultra-powerful tool for 3D graphics professionals—at SIGGRAPH 2006, held on the first of August this year. The event saw about 1300 users in all their eagerness, packed into the auditorium. In its wake, Senior Director of Product Management for Autodesk's Media & Entertainment Division Michel Besner was recently on a tour of the Asia-Pacific region to promote the product and interact with 3D user groups in the region. We had a little chat with him about the future of 3dsmax, Maya, 64-bit computing and a good bit more.



Michel Besner
Autodesk

On The Community

"We're increasing focus on our user community, and we've launched The Area (www.thearea.com) on August 22, which is all about building Autodesk's community and will give users a platform to interact with and learn from each other. We've already got Autodesk Labs (labs.autodesk.com), which is where developers and testers give feedback on our products. The Personal Learning Editions of Maya and MotionBuilder have

involved hobbyists as well, as has the 30-day trial of 3dsmax 8."

On The Future Of 3dsmax And Maya:

"Both tools are going to evolve separately—contrary to many beliefs, we aren't killing any products which were in the Alias line-up. Collaboration abilities are being enhanced—something that will be very helpful in India, with all the offshore projects that go on here. Finally, the new FBX file format will work seamlessly with 3dsmax, Maya and

MotionBuilder, so a studio can either be all 3dsmax, all Maya, or a mix of both if they choose to. We've announced 3dsmax 9 at SIGGRAPH, and it should begin shipping in a month or two."

On 64-bit Computing

"Our focus with 64-bit is more on getting data into memory rather than the speed of computing. Both 3dsmax and Maya are going to be fully 64-bit, and this will be a huge advantage for complex projects that need to load a lot of information into memory. The 2 GB limit of current platforms is very limiting, and going 64-bit shatters that barrier."

event objects. *Model-driven Architecture* will draw a clear line between functionality and its implementation. This will help model applications in a standard format, without bothering about the nuances of the platform it will be deployed on.

The publishing of the hype cycle will help businesses decide what technology is best for them in this ever-evolving online world.

SYMANTEC CRIES FOUL

Criticises Vista's Closed Kernel

After its criticism of Windows Vista's network stack, followed by its slamming of the

annoying User Access Control, Symantec still hungers for more Microsoft blood as it throws another burning brick at the new operating system—its closed kernel is hampering security innovations, they say.

The kernel is the heart of any operating system, and naturally, malware authors are always looking to give it a heart attack. However, Microsoft has blocked access to the kernel for security software, instead taking kernel security into their own hands, causing this disgruntlement. The Vista kernel will periodically check for integrity, and will require all third party drivers to be certified by an independent authority.

However, malware authors have already demonstrated that this approach is far from foolproof, and that these

kernel security features can be circumvented. This makes it possible to install a rootkit on the machine, putting it under the complete control of a hacker. All this while security software still remains locked out of the kernel. "These new technologies, along with Microsoft's unwillingness to make compromises in this area have serious implications for the security industry as a whole," says Oliver Friedrichs, director of Emerging Technologies at Symantec Security Response.

Let's face it—security isn't really the strong point of a Microsoft OS, and locking out the firms that *do* keep Windows secure isn't the best plan. They need to provide access to security vendors so that they, too, can keep innovating and head off hackers. ■